Conflict Resolution

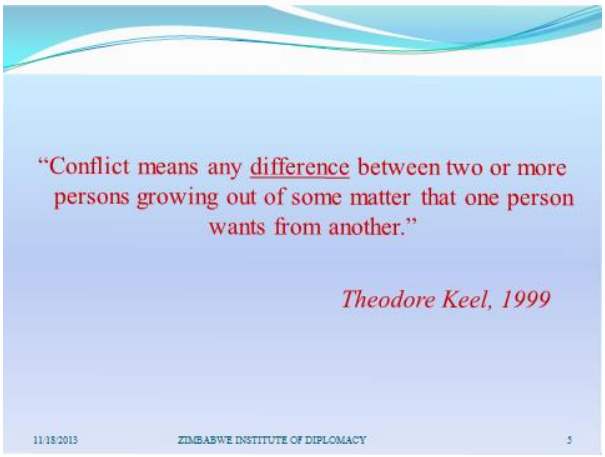
Resolving Conflicts Maintaining Relationships



Agenda

- Defining conflict
- Reasons for conflict
- Handling conflict [conflict management]
- Practical steps to conflict resolution
- Final thoughts





"When we use the term conflict, we're referring to *perceived* incompatible differences resulting in some form of interference or opposition. Whether differences are real or not is irrelevant. If people in a group perceive that differences exist, then a conflict state exists."

Robbins & Coulter, 1999

"We define conflict as a disagreement through which the parties involved perceive a threat to their needs, interests or concerns."

Key Assumptions about Conflict

- **Differences & disagreement (discord, friction, disharmony)**
- **Between individuals & parties**
- **Because of *perceived* threat**
- **Interests, needs, or concerns**

Reasons for Conflict

1. Pride & Prejudice
2. Greed
3. Imperfections
4. Scarce resources (water, oil, food, land)
5. Jurisdictional ambiguities, Independence
6. Personality clashes
7. Power difference
8. Status difference
9. Goals, desires
10. **Values, interests**
11. Beliefs, principles
12. Culture difference
13. Needs difference [***Maslow's Pyramid***]
14. Threats
15. Fear
16. Injustices
17. Communication breakdown
18. Lack of communication
19. Perceptions
20. Emotions
21. Attitude
22. Honor
23. Lack of action, etc.…

Reasons for Conflict in a Business Setting

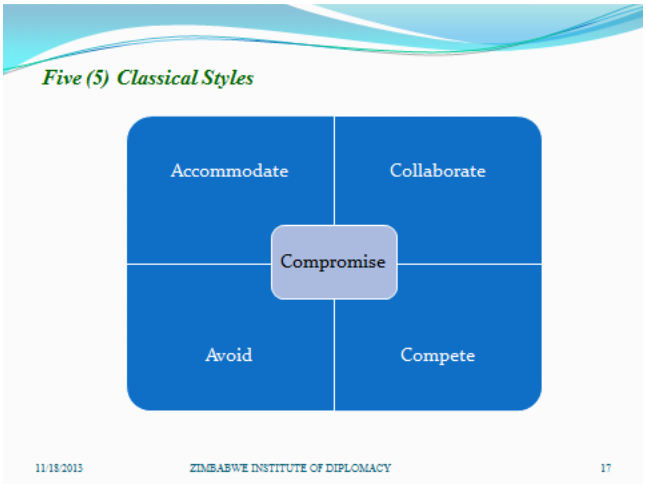
1. Communication styles
2. Personality differences
3. Breach of contract
4. Quality issues
5. Terms & conditions
6. Customer defaults
7. Misalignment of goals
8. Lack of understanding
9. Insecurities, fear
10. Lack of leadership
11. Roles
12. Gap between company culture and individual culture
13. Loss of respect, etc.
14. Psychological

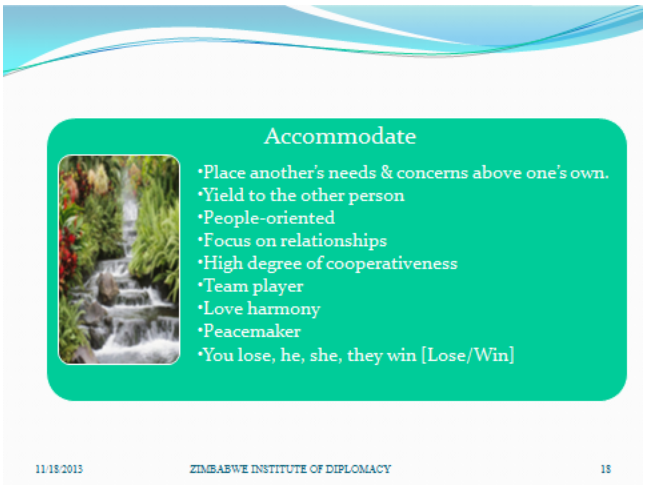
15. Physiological
16. Political
17. Socio-cultural
18. Anthropological
19. Philosophical
20. Religious
21. Physical
22. Legal
23. Internal/external
24. Functional/operational
25. Gender-based, etc…

Views About Conflict

Traditional View: conflict is bad and must be avoided
Human Relations View: conflict is natural and inevitable. It is not necessarily bad or negative. It could be a positive force
Interactionist View: Conflict is positive and some conflict is absolutely necessary for a group to perform effectively. (*Some conflict could be destructive*)
Realist's View: Conflict is neither positive nor negative in and of itself. It is how we handle conflict that could prove negative or positive
The New View: Conflict can serve as opportunities for mutual growth…can bring out alternative ways of thinking and behaving…conflict is an outgrowth of diversity

Handling Conflict Styles





The Accommodating Style reflects a high degree of cooperativeness, which works best when people realize that they are wrong, when an issue is more important to others than oneself, when building social credits…, and when maintaining harmony is especially important.



The Avoiding Style reflects neither assertiveness nor cooperativeness. This style is appropriate when:

1. an issue is trivial
2. when there is no chance of winning
3. when a delay to gather more information is needed
4. when disruption will be very costly

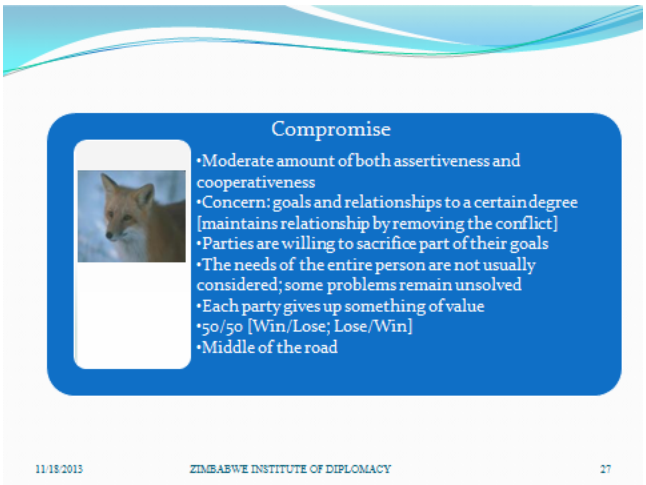
Avoidance: withdrawal or suppression of conflict. This is used when emotions are running high and time is needed to cool down.

The Avoiding Style merely postpones dealing with the conflict and usually allows it to worsen. It deprives the parties of opportunities for important personal growth….It denies the parties…the possibilities of improvement.



The Competing Style reflects assertiveness to get one's own way. Should be used when quick decisive action is vital on important issues or unpopular actions, such as during emergencies or urgent cost cutting.

- The Competing Style (Conquest Approach): the conflict becomes a battle to win. This style could poison the atmosphere, obstruct the effectiveness of the company, cause severe problems in working relationships and makes life miserable.
- This approach depends on dominance, bullying and manipulation. It perpetuates an unhealthy relationship and restricts options for resolving conflicts.
- The conquered party is disempowered and demoralized. All parties suffer including the winner. Winner enjoys short-term advantage.



The Compromising Style reflects a moderate amount of both assertiveness and cooperativeness. It is appropriate:

1. when the goals on both sides are equally important,
2. when opponents have equal power and both sides want to split the difference,
3. or when people need to arrive at temporary or expedient solutions under time pressure.

The Compromising Style may create less than ideal outcome and game playing can result.



The Collaborating Style reflects both a high degree of assertiveness and cooperativeness. It enables both parties to win, although it may require substantial bargaining and negotiation. The collaborating style is important:

1. when both sets of concerns are too important to be compromised ,

2. when insights from different people need to be merged into an overall solution,
3. and when commitment of both sides is needed for consensus.

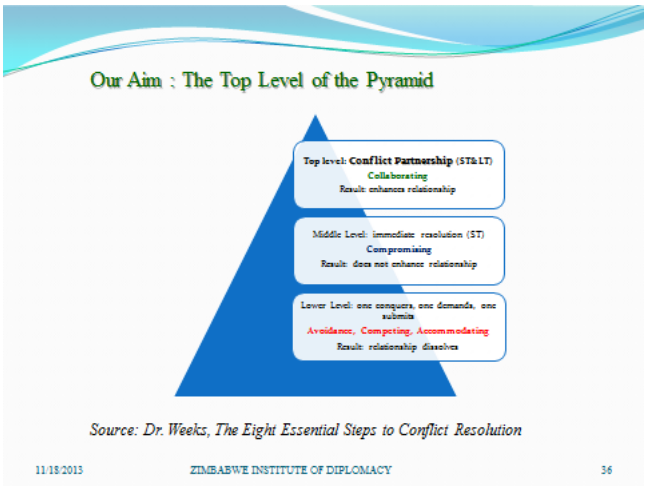
The Collaborating Style is the ultimate win-win solution….All parties to the conflict…seek to satisfy their interests. This style is based on open and honest discussion among the parties, active listening to understand differences, and careful deliberation over a full range of alternatives to find a solution that is advantageous to all. This option can be used when:

1. Time pressures are minimal
2. And when all parties want a win-win solution

Redefining Conflict Resolution

Conflict Resolution is the process of applying a multidisciplinary approach to resolve a dispute or a conflict. It is an amalgam of psychology, philosophy, political science, sociology, anthropology, law, etc. There is no one-size-fits-all approach. The ultimate goal of conflict resolution should be to maintain and strengthen long-term relationships while trying to seek the satisfaction of the needs, interests, and concerns of all parties involved.

Introducing A New Approach





The Conflict Partnership Approach deals with the conflict in a way that opens up possibilities for improving the relationship as well as resolving the conflict at hand. It sees the specific conflict as just one part of the relationship. The goal is not to defeat the other party and seize a temporary advantage, but rather to develop a sustainable resolution of the conflict, made possible in part because an improvement in the relationship has been established. Conflict Partnership is a transformation.

An Integrative Foursquare Approach (P-SAP)

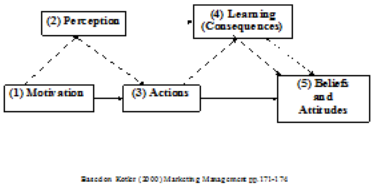
- Psychological perspective
- Sociological perspective
- Anthropological perspective
- Political perspective

Psychological Perspective

This perspective explains that a motivated person is ready to act. But how he or she actually acts is influenced by his or her perception of the situation. Further, when people act, they learn. And "through doing and learning, people acquire beliefs and attitudes" that influence their behavior (Kotler, 2000:171-74).

Integrative Approach

- Psychological perspective



Basedon Kotler (2000) Marketing Management pp 171-176

Integrative Approach

- Sociological Perspective

This perspective highlights the application of the Thomas Theorem. It states: "If men define situations as real, they are real in their consequences" (Merton, 1968:475).

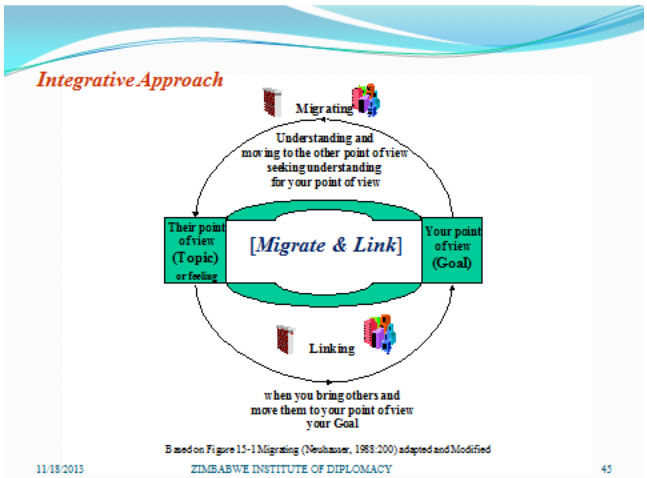
Perception could be based on wrong premise

Integrative Approach

- Anthropological Perspective

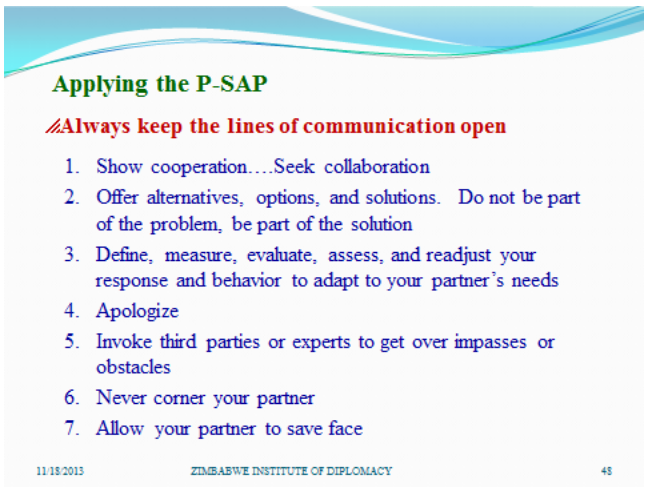
"Anthropologically,…groups in organizations act very much like "real" tribes; they have their own dialects, values, histories, ways of thinking, and rules for appropriate behavior…Each tribe or culture has its own rules that govern its thinking and behavior and that these rules usually operate at a subconscious level."

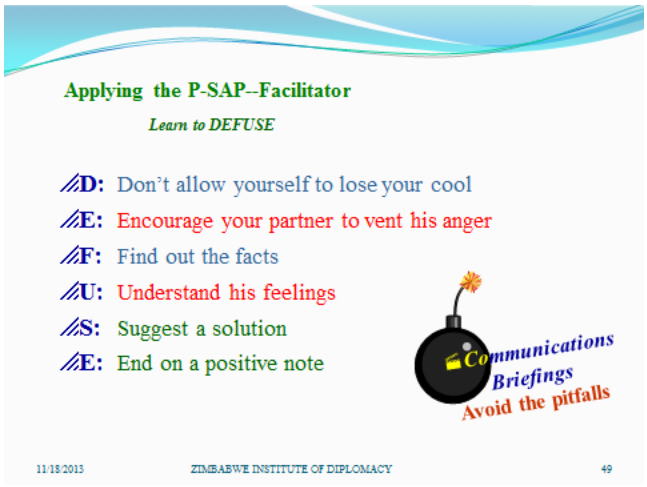
Neuhauser (1988:4-5), in Tribal Warfare in Organizations, writes:



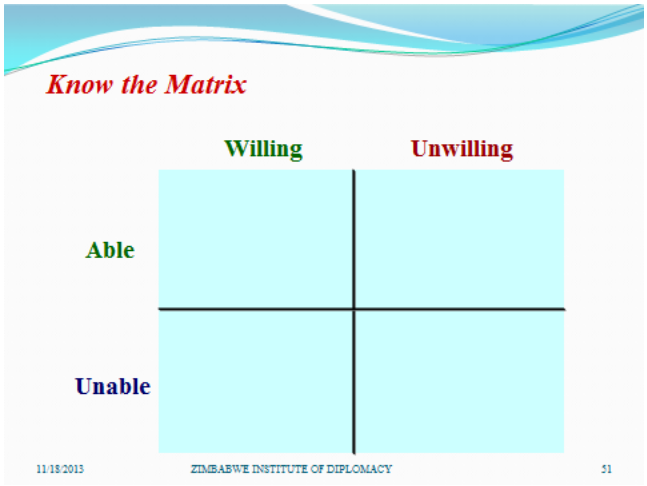


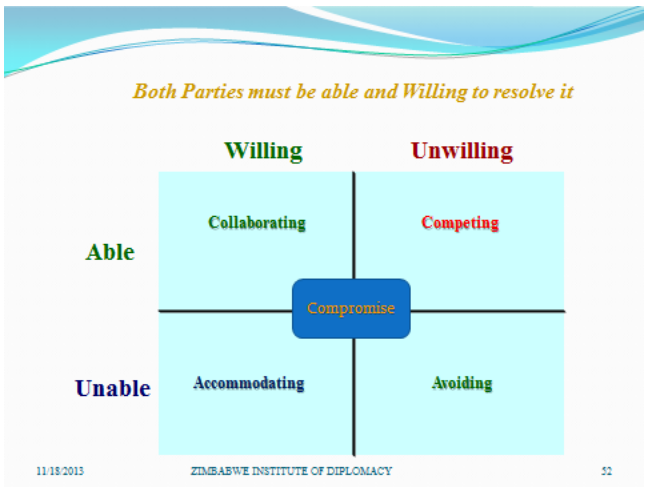
Applying the P-SAP





Key Success Factor







Practical Steps to Resolve a Conflict: Johnson 1990 (using the collaborative style)

1. Confront the Opposing Party [let the other party know of the conflict]
2. Define the Conflict Together
3. Communicate Personal Positions and Feelings
4. Express Your Cooperative Intentions
5. Understand the Conflict from the Other Party's Viewpoint
6. Be Motivated to Negotiate in Good Faith
7. Reach an Agreement

Practical Steps to Resolve a Conflict: Dr. Weeks 1992 (eight essential steps to conflict resolution)

1. Create an effective atmosphere
2. Clarify perceptions
3. Focus on individual and shared needs
4. Build shared positive power
5. Look to the future, then learn from the past
6. Generate options
7. Develop “doables” : The stepping-stones to action
8. Make mutual-benefits agreements

Practical Steps to Resolve a Conflict: Doyle & Haydock 1991 (without the punches)

1. Foster a trusting relationship
2. Discuss mutual and complimentary interests

3. Have an open exchange of what each party wants
4. Discuss alternatives and options
5. Strive to reach a result that satisfies both parties
6. Exchange greetings

Practical Steps to Resolve a Conflict

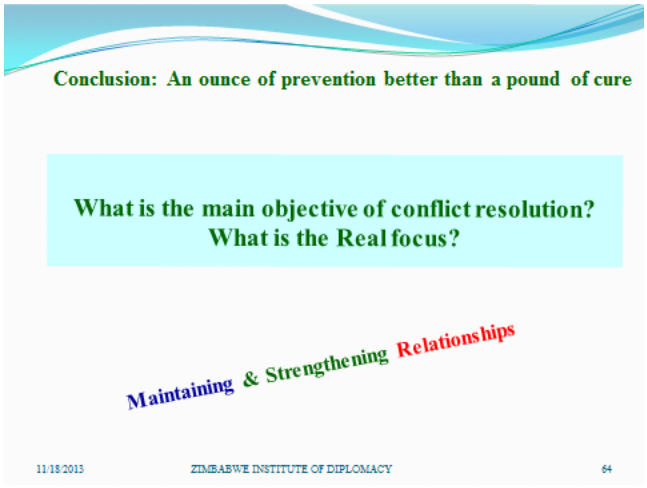
Avoid the pitfalls [Why the failure?]

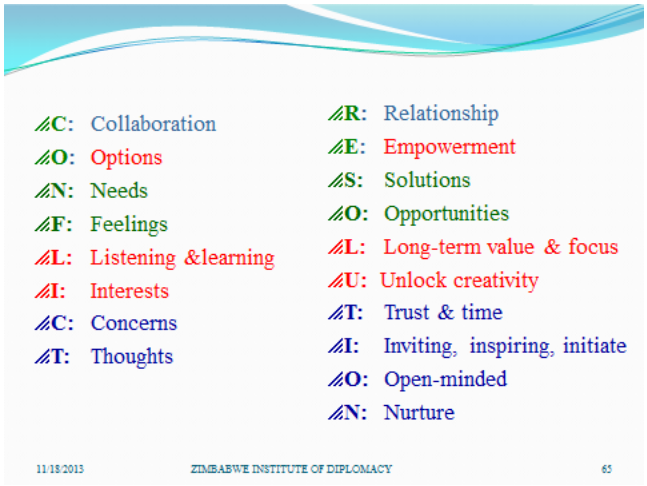
1. Adversarial relationships
2. Attempt to persuade each other of the correctness of their positions, instead of attempting to resolve the differences
3. Failure to define the issues
4. Become stubborn and refuse to engage in mutually beneficial compromises
5. Strong personality clashes
6. Engaging in one-way dialogue

Final Thoughts

1. Listen, listen, listen to the conflict partner
2. Keep the lines of communication open
3. Seek options and alternatives
4. Be courteous; show respect. Always honor and respect your partner(s)
5. Acknowledge their fears, feelings, emotions, and needs
6. Respect their point of view
7. Do not fall into the I versus them atmosphere
8. Do not lock yourself into rigid demands
9. Understand the power of perception
10. Look into feelings, emotions and commonalities
11. Focus on thoughts, needs & wants
12. Ask questions
13. Show interest in your partner
14. Attack the issues not the person
15. Do not stereotype
16. Reach for positive power
17. Seek doables
18. Use differences for mutual growth
19. Be honest and sincere
20. Avoid ploys , games and manipulations

Conflict Resolution is the process of attempting to resolve a dispute or a conflict. Successful conflict resolution occurs by listening to and providing opportunities to meet the needs of all parties, and to adequately address interests so that each party is satisfied with the outcome. Conflict Practitioners talk about finding the win-win outcome for parties involved, vs. the win-lose dynamic found in most conflicts. While 'conflict resolution' engages conflict once it has already started , 'conflict prevention' aims to end conflicts before they start or before they lead to verbal, physical, or legal fighting or violence.





"A focus on interests can resolve the problem underlying the dispute more effectively than a focus on rights or power."

Ury, Brett, & Goldberg